

What are your strengths and weaknesses?

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This is a question asked to check how you look at yourself and also how your strengths can contribute to the team.

Be honest and tell what you consider as your strengths ('I learn new skills fast', 'I am an effective team player', 'I have good leadership skills', etc). Provide supporting details for your strengths ('I learn new skills fast. In my previous job, I had to learn scripting. I started to do shell programming from the next day itself, and I did it!'). For weaknesses, don't elaborate too much; some weaknesses can cost you your job ('I can't resist stealing if I see costly mobiles!').

What do you know about our company?

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This question is to check if you would be interested in working in that company (if you're a kernel hacker, it is unlikely that you'll be interested in Web programming, assuming that the company develops Web-based software). It is also to check if you're keenly interested in joining the company—if you're going for higher studies and attending interviews 'just-like-that', then you would not have shown much interest in knowing more about that company, right?

To answer this question you should prepare before attending the interview. Visit the company's website to know about the company. If you know anyone working in the company, contact them and get an idea of what the company works on, which countries (or states) it has a presence in, the kind of projects or products they are working on, etc. An overview of the company is more than enough.

What do you think of your previous boss?

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This question is to check how well you can work with, or relate to your new boss if you get the job.

Speak about a few good things you found while working with your previous boss. However, you can't be too open in answering this question!

Why are you planning to leave your current job?

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Be careful in answering this question.

Usually acceptable answers are: 'Looking for better pay'; 'looking for a better role and growth opportunities'; 'Got married and had to shift to this city'. Bad answers: 'I didn't like my old boss!' (you're too frank to get this job!); 'The project is nearing the deadline and I don't want to work in that hectic schedule' (you can't desert your project when it is in a critical situation!); 'I had to work!' (come on, you're paid for doing your work!).

Tell us about some challenges you faced in your previous job and how you overcame them.

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This question is asked to check how confident you are in handling your day-to-day work and also your confidence in sticky situations.

You can briefly explain some of the challenges that you faced in your earlier jobs, how you dealt with them, how your team or managers helped you, and how you successfully overcame the problems finally. Avoid talking about bad experiences. Also avoid blaming anyone or the team for any problem. It is better to talk about technical challenges and problems.

Are you a team player?

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Sometimes the interviewer asks you this question directly. This question is also asked indirectly, as in: 'Do you prefer working in teams or working alone?' or 'How comfortable are you in working as a member in a large team?' This question is to check how good and comfortable you are in working as a team player (particularly in a few types of jobs where team work is very important).

Obviously we need to say, 'Yes', but support your answer with more details or by giving a few instances in the past where you worked very well as a team player. If you are a fresher, you can talk about your participation in or organizing of team sports events, get-togethers, etc.

Focus more about team strength than about individual abilities. This question could also lead to questions like how you handled conflicts within the team. So be prepared!